

Beneath the Black Hole Sun



Welcome! You are formally invited to play in a homebrewed D&D 5e mini-campaign called *Beneath the Black Hole Sun*, DM'd by yours truly. This document will help you gain an understanding of the world, how to create your character and real world expectations, should you choose to accept this invitation. For this mini-campaign, I was thinking of beginning your characters at level 11, and planning for *roughly* 5 bi-weekly sessions. Given the significant number of players who have indicated interest in joining the campaign, I think the most fun and sustainable way of running this campaign is what they call a “West Marches” style campaign. In particular, I want to run **two** tables! Each table will interact with parts of the world, but you may not be aware of what occurs during the other table’s sessions. For now, I plan to DM roughly every week with one table, but you will take turns alternating, meaning *every other week you should plan to be present* to join your table’s adventures. For the final session, I would like to see if it is possible to combine both tables for an epic conclusion. If that sounds like fun to you, please read on to learn more.

Setting Overview

The world of *Asterfall* lives beneath a dead sun. The sun collapsed into a black hole generations ago. The world is dimly lit by the burning halo of the black hole's accretion disk, but true daylight is gone. The sky is a black pupil ringed in fire. Embers of civilization survive in the shadow of this cosmic catastrophe.

Two great powers are at war.

"The Halo Crown" is a gleaming theocratic society fighting the darkness with miracles. They believe the world can be restored to light through sufficient faith, sacrifice and perhaps remnants from the past.

Whereas **"The Ashen Freeholds"** are a militarized confederation of clans that have adapted to the darkness through discipline, resilience and pragmatism. They believe the age of sunlight is over, and that trying to restore it will doom everyone.

Each kingdom also has vassal houses or distinct clans which add complexity to the political landscape. Your character belongs to one of these societies, or has been caught between them.

The war is not simple. Your kingdom *may* be right, but at what costs?

You must pick a kingdom to join. Or at least have a reason to fight with one of them. This will dictate which table you play with, so I encourage you all to vote which best represents your group's collective interests.

If it's not clear by now the campaign will explore themes of war, duty, sacrifice, trust, and ethics. Mortals (humans, elves, dwarves, etc.), aberrations (monstrosities), and perhaps undead or divine entities (angels, demons, etc.) should be the most common characters/enemies you should expect to interact with. This is intended to be a grimdark universe, you may have to make the best of a bad situation. **Please consult the mood board** at the end of the document to better understand the themes and tone of the game.

Character Creation

Please fill out the following sections to help me understand your character, so that I can properly weave them into our story. **Your answers will shape the world** and the narrative, making our sessions more rich and engaging. These questions are designed to be suggestive and get you in the headspace of your character. Be creative! If it's too much, I can walk you through it all. Regardless, I will need time to process everyone's characters and incorporate them into the story, so discuss with me this sheet as soon as possible.

Part I: Basic Character Information

Character Name:

Player Name:

Kingdom:

Choose one:

- The Halo Crown
- The Ashen Freeholds
- Formerly neutral / foreign / unaffiliated

Ancestry / Race:

Class(es):

Subclass, if known:

Background:

Age:

What does your character look like?

e.g. clothing, armor, scars, religious symbols, military markings, masks, weapons, or other distinctive details.

What kind of character arc are you interested in exploring throughout these sessions? We will only have a few sessions to construct our story. So consider beforehand what type of changes we might expect to see in your character.

- Example arcs: Redemption, processing grief, self-discovery, overcoming fear, seeking revenge, achieving a long-held goal, fall from grace.

Part II: Your Kingdom

- **If you are from The Halo Crown**

The Halo Crown is a radiant theocratic realm of cathedral-cities, artificial dawn farms, bell towers, and holy armies. It believes darkness is a wound and that the world must be restored.

Answer any that interest you:

1. Do you truly believe the sun can be restored?
2. What does “light” mean to you: (e.g. hope, control, truth, purity, comfort, propaganda, or something else?)
3. What part of Halo Crown society shaped you most?
 - the church
 - the military
 - a noble house
 - a monastery
 - an artificial dawn farm
 - a hospital
 - the poor districts beneath the cathedral light
4. Have you personally witnessed a miracle?
5. What do you think the Crown is right about?
6. What do you suspect the Crown is lying about?
7. What would you sacrifice to see the true sun restored?
8. What would make you turn against the Crown?

- **If you are from The Ashen Freeholds**

The Ashen Freeholds are a confederation of military clans, guerilla combatants, survivalist holds, and armies that embrace the dark. They believe the world has changed and that humanity must change with it.

Answer any that interest you:

1. Do you believe the age of sunlight is truly over?
2. What does “darkness” mean to you: (e.g. freedom, honesty, hardship, adaptation, grief, strength, or something else?)
3. What part of Freehold society shaped you most?
 - a warrior clan
 - a border fortress
 - an ancestor shrine
 - a military academy
 - a scavenger caravan
 - a family of refugees or survivors
4. What survival custom do you follow that outsiders might find unsettling?
5. What do you think the Freeholds are right about?
6. What do you suspect the Freeholds are lying about?
7. Do you trust the Freehold generals, clan-chiefs, and war councils?
8. What would you sacrifice to keep humanity adapted to the dark?
9. What would make you betray the Freeholds?

- **If you are from elsewhere**

Please discuss with me what you had in mind for your character’s background and motivations.

Part III: House, Clan, Order, or Faction

Each kingdom contains smaller powers. Your character should have some connection to one of them. This is a perfect time to collaborate with one or more of your table mates, it can help foster deeper connection and create interesting interplay at each table.

Choose or invent one:

Faction / House / Clan / Order Name:

What kind of power does this faction hold? (e.g.: military command, religious authority, food production, medicine, engineering, espionage, noble bloodline, trade, monster hunting, forbidden research, control of relics, ancestral law, criminal networks, etc.):

What does your faction want from the war?

What does your faction publicly claim to value?

What does your faction secretly value?

Who in your faction do you distrust?

What scandal, crime, or shame could damage your faction if exposed?

Would your character protect the faction, reform it, exploit it, or escape it?

Part IV: Your Place in Society

I recommend to pick 1-3 questions to answer:

1. Were you born into status?
2. Are you respected, useful, disposable, feared, or tolerated?
3. What does your society expect of you?
4. What role do you actually want for yourself?
5. Who has authority over you?
6. Who depends on you?
7. What privilege do you have that others do not?
8. What burden do you carry that others do not see?
9. What would people assume about you based on your class, house, clan, faith, or background?
10. Are those assumptions fair?

Part V: The War

I recommend to pick 1-3 questions to answer:

1. What were you taught about how the war began?
2. Do you believe that version?
3. Have you killed for your kingdom? If not, are you prepared to?
4. Have you lost someone to the war?
5. What do you hate most about the enemy kingdom?
6. What do you secretly admire about the enemy kingdom?
7. Have you ever met someone from the other side who challenged your beliefs?
8. What would victory look like to you?
9. What should peace cost?
10. What truth, if revealed, would make the war feel meaningless?

Part VI: Relationships

Name/Create at least one NPC your character knows.

NPC 1

Name:

Relationship to you:

What do they want from you?

What do you want from them?

Are they loyal to your kingdom, your faction, themselves, or something else?

Part VII: Party Connections

Last one, answer at least one, TALK TO YOUR OTHER PLAYERS.

1. Which other player character do you already know?
2. Which other player character do you trust most?
3. Which other player character do you distrust, and why?
4. Which character has seen you at your worst?
5. Which character knows a secret about you?
6. Which character did you save, fail, betray, or protect?
7. What shared mission, disaster, or patron brought the party together?

Annnnd you made it! Thank you very much for putting such thoughtful consideration into your character. I guarantee it will pay off in the end. Below is an attached mood board for the campaign, check it out! Now that the hard part is almost done, let's play already!

Mood Board